



and stylish all-court game. Unfortunately, injuries have often derailed her career and, amazingly, she has won only three career titles, two of which came this year at Bad Homburg and Doha. Before this Wimbledon, the 5'11" Muchova had reached only one Slam final, at the 2023 French Open. It also ended in a heartbreaking defeat. She was twice ahead by a service break against Iga Swiatek, then the Queen of Clay, in the deciding set, before bowing 6-2, 5-7, 6-4.

Czech recipe for success

Both Noskova and Muchova racked up 11-1 records on grass this season going into the final, and Noskova leads the Tour with 19 wins on grass since 2025. That may surprise tennis fans, given the Czech Republic has no grass courts. Asked how this country of 10.9 million people produces so many great players, Czech-born Martina Navratilova, who amassed 58 Major titles in singles, doubles, and mixed doubles, told *Tennis Channel*, "Inexpensive access [to tennis], great coaching, and they play sets at the clubs so they're ready for pro tournaments." Former No. 1 Wozniacki offered a fourth reason. "They see all the great Czech players before them and think, why not me?"

Indeed, three of the last four Wimbledon singles champions came through the Czech system — Barbora Krejcikova in 2023, Marketa Vondrousova in 2024, and now Noskova. In doubles, current No. 1 Katerina Siniakova has captured 11 Grand Slam titles (seven with Krejcikova) and an Olympic gold medal.

None of the pre-tournament favourites, except for Gauff, reached the semifinals. Naomi Osaka overpowered the slumping world No. 1 Aryna Sabalenka 6-2, 7-6(2) to make her first Wimbledon quarterfinal. "It's been a long time since I've had so much fun on a court," Osaka said afterwards. The sport's leading fashionista, Osaka optimistically brought seven outfits — as Venus Williams used to do — but Muchova stopped her run, 7-6(4), 6-4, in her fifth match.

Elena Rybakina, the 2022 Wimbledon and 2026 Australian champion, was upset by Mertens 7-6(4), 6-1 in the third round. Defending champion Swiatek was dethroned 7-6(9), 6-2 by 29th-seeded Alexandra Eala, an immensely popular Filipina, whom Mary Joe Fernandez touted as "a rising superstar."

Krejcikova, the versatile, savvy

Brave run: Rising No. 12 seed Marta Kostyuk fell to Noskova in the other semifinal. AFP

two-time Major champion, outlasted No. 5-seeded Andreeva, the recent Roland Garros queen, 4-6, 7-5, 6-4. And in a battle of American power hitters, No. 6-seeded and defending finalist Amanda Anisimova, hampered by a flurry of forehand errors and a negative attitude, was ousted by Madison Keys 3-6, 6-2, 6-3.

What about the legend Serena Williams, now a 44-year-old mother of two daughters? Nearly four years ago at the US Open, she supposedly played her last match but refused to say she had retired, instead insisting she was "evolving away" from the pro tour. Accepting a wild card, the ultimate warrior of yesteryear played Maya Joint, an undersized, 20-year-old Australian who had idolised Serena as a child but had lost her previous 11 matches.

Before a packed, curious crowd, including a female spectator in a T-shirt with 'Unstoppable Queen' printed on it, Serena lacked the power, mobility, and match toughness of her 23-Major-title prime and predictably succumbed 6-3, 6-7(6), 6-3. Serena, who tweaked her right knee at the end of the first set, pulled out of the doubles, which she had entered with Venus.

That early sideshow was soon overshadowed by two Czech mates. Noskova became the tenth different woman to win Wimbledon since 2016, when Queen Serena captured her seventh and last ladies' crown on the hallowed lawns of the All England Club.

This women's tennis parity — or depth, as the WTA likes to say — extends to all surfaces. Noskova became the seventh different Grand Slam champion since the start of 2025. But spreading wealth too much has its downsides: no captivating superstars or compelling rivalries like the legendary men's Big Three or the new Big Two.

Will Noskova — who has all the shots, athleticism, and the poise — be the one to step up and become the sport's next superstar?